

VALMIKI CORPORATION SCAM
Nagendra resigns from Karnataka Cabinet
NEWS » PAGE 4

RURAL JOB SCHEME
e-KYC target unmet for 57 lakh active workers
NEWS » PAGE 5

BILATERAL TIES
India, Canada reaffirm 2026 trade deal target
BUSINESS » PAGE 11

HARYANA'S KHAP DIKTATS
Old rules and new rebels
As community bodies prescribe social norms, Gen Z pushes back
GROUND ZERO » PAGE 7

REMARKABLE FEAT
Praggnanandhaa wins the Grand Chess Tour
SPORT » PAGE 14

INSIDE



Dhaka open to join the Mecca Defence Pact

DHAKA
Bangladesh to consider joining the Mecca Pact, a defence deal signed by Saudi, Turkiye and Pakistan, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Dr. Khalilur Rahman said on Thursday. » PAGE 12

Panel on exam reforms seeks suggestions

NEW DELHI
A high-powered task force constituted by the Centre to recommend reforms to public exams, including those held by the National Testing Agency, has invited suggestions from stakeholders, such as students, parents, teachers, and institutions. » PAGE 5



Govt. eases norms for defence exports, licences

NEW DELHI
The Defence Ministry has simplified export and licensing norms. Under the revised Defence Export Standard Operating Procedure (SOP), stakeholder consultation has been dispensed with for exports of non-lethal defence items to most places. » PAGE 3

Nepal disaster toll rises to 579 amid search for 2,000 missing

More than 4,500 people, including 85 Indians, rescued; people from more than 30 countries are among those missing; Nepal govt. allows foreign experts to join the search operation following intense diplomatic pressure; flood risk continues



Hopes alive: Relatives wait for the helicopter to arrive, hoping their family members will return, at the Nepal Army's rescue centre in Nuwakot, on Friday. PRABHAT KHANAL

Sanjeev Satgajanya
KATHMANDU

The death toll in the Nepal flash floods touched 579 on Friday, even as the search for nearly 2,000 missing people continued for the third day after the disaster struck.

The Nepal Police said more than 4,500 people had been rescued. Of the 183 Indian tourists reported missing, 85 had been rescued while 98 remained unaccounted for, the Nepal Tourism Board said.

Indians account for the highest number of missing foreign nationals.

People from more than 30 countries are among those reported missing, the Board said. They include 65 from the United States, 61 from Ukraine, 51

from Malaysia, 35 from Australia, and 33 from the United Kingdom.

Meanwhile, Nepal has reversed its earlier decision not to seek assistance from international search teams. Sources said the government decided to seek help from foreign experts in limited areas following intense diplomatic pressure from countries whose citizens remained unaccounted for.

In a social media post, Prime Minister Balendra Shah said the government was continuously coordinating with India, China and international partners on the assistance and supplies needed for rescue and relief operations.

Amid questions over how flooding on such a massive scale could have occurred in the Bhotekoshi

‘No contact with 320 Indians, 400 stranded’

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

At least 320 Indians were not contactable while 400 others were stranded on the Chinese side after the

river in the Rasuwa district when no rain was recorded, scientists are working to piece together the chain of events.

Nepali authorities have said the disaster may have originated in the Lhende Khola on the Nepali side.

The Lhende Khola is a transboundary, high-altitude river that originates in Gyirong County in Tibet

and flows south into Nepal, where it joins the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 4

and flows south into Nepal, where it joins the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers.

Scientists believe an ice-and-rock collapse may have sent debris into the Lhende valley, temporarily blocking the river before a massive surge of water and debris swept downstream into the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers.

Nepal's Department of

Hydrology and Meteorology, drawing on satellite imagery shared by the Chinese side, has reached a similar preliminary conclusion. “The avalanche originated on the Nepali side, but very close to the boundary, and caused the floods that crossed the Nepal-China border,” said Binod Parajuli, a senior divisional hydrologist at the department's Flood Forecasting Division.

He said a full technical assessment was still pending, as the department's immediate focus was on rescue work. He said there was still a risk of flooding, although it was unlikely to be on the same scale, and urged people living in the area to exercise caution.

RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGE 4 & 6

Penguin India pulls Sonia memoir over ‘PM, RSS references’

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Penguin Random House India announced on Friday that it is not publishing Congress leader Sonia Gandhi's much-awaited autobiography *Belonging: A Journey of Love* with industry sources saying that the publisher and author had differences regarding content related to her impressions of Prime Minister Narendra Modi from official meetings, his handling of India-China ties, and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and its activities.

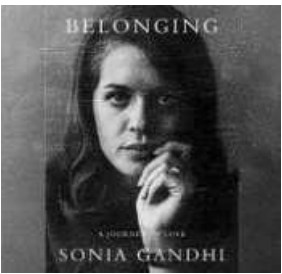
Responding to news reports, the Indian publisher issued the following statement on Friday: “Penguin Random House India is not the publisher of *Belonging* in India. Any suggestion that Penguin Random House India decided not to publish *Belonging* because the author declined editorial changes does not accurately reflect the circumstances.”

It added: “As a publisher, it is both our prerogative and our responsibility to fact-check and provide authors with recommendations that are in the best interests of their books... Throughout the relevant discussions, Penguin Random House India's position was that we remained willing and keen to publish the book.”

International edition

It is learned that the book's international publisher, Alfred A. Knopf, will include the sections that the Penguin Random House objected to in the version to be published for sale outside India.

Sources said that Ms. Gandhi's manuscript ran



The cover image of Sonia Gandhi's autobiography.

Book's international publisher, Alfred A. Knopf, will include the sections Penguin India objected to

into trouble at the stage of legal scrutiny, which has become a trend over the last decade.

When the legal team's feedback to remove or alter the sections related to the PM, the RSS, and Ms. Gandhi's opinion on India-China relations was communicated to the author, they were reportedly told that this is a story of her life, and she would not alter anything in the manuscript as self-censorship would interfere with the story-telling process.

Ms. Gandhi has been working on the book for several years and had consulted her close friends, including a few authors, in the process of her research and writing, *The Hindu* has learnt.

Ms. Gandhi's office has not commented on the matter.

The book, charting Ms. Gandhi's journey from Italy to India, will be published for international readers on November 10, Alfred A. Knopf announced on August 18.

CONG. SLAMS PUBLISHER
» PAGE 3

IIP slows to 6.7% in July; economists warn of sluggish rural consumption

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India's industrial growth in July 2026 stood at 6.7%, slower than the 8.8% seen in June.

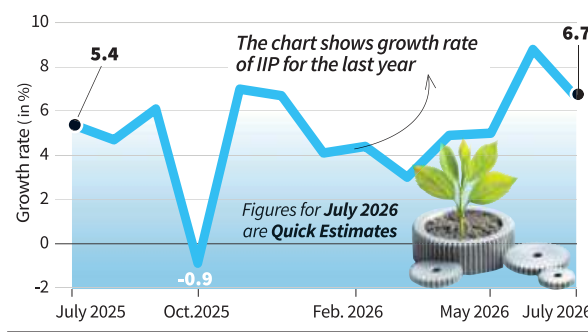
July's performance of the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) was, however, the second-best growth the index has seen since December last year, and was buoyed by the manufacturing and electricity and gas supply sectors. The IIP data released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation also saw June's IIP growth upgraded from the provisional 7.3% announced last month to 8.8%.

According to economists, the data in particular shows a divergence in India's consumption trends, with rural consumption levels exhibiting weakness.

The manufacturing sector grew by 7.3% in July

Growth dips

India's industrial growth rate fell to **6.7% in July 2026**, the second-best growth recorded by the Index since December last year



2026, down from the 9.5% it saw in June, but faster than the 5.1% growth in July of last year. “The manufacturing sector growth was propelled by industries like engineering [electric and non-electrical] and automobiles [all kinds of transport] besides electronics and plastic and rubber products,” Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at the Bank of Baroda, said.

Industries such as beverages, wood, paper, and non-metallic minerals also supported this relatively high growth, he said.

Rajeev Sharan, head of research at Brickwork Ratings, however, said the main 6.7% growth in the IIP might be overstating “the breadth of the recovery” as the underlying data shows a split in the way Indians are spending their

money. That is, the data seems to suggest that expenditure on daily-use items is slowing while spending on durables seems to be doing well.

“The July numbers show a widening gap in household spending,” Mr. Sharan said. “Consumer durables, the big-ticket items such as vehicles and appliances, grew 10.5%, while everyday goods such as food and toiletries [consumer non-durables] fell 1%,” he added.

Mr. Sharan added that a similar split runs through factory output, with the motor vehicles sector up 22.2% and electrical equipment up 28.3%, while food products grew a much slower 2.6% and clothing contracted 0.6%. “This suggests discretionary and credit-linked purchases remain strong, while everyday items, more closely tied to rural incomes, remain weak,” he said.

India signs Javelin procurement deal with U.S., boosts defence ties

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

India signed a Letter of Offer and Acceptance (LOA) with the U.S. on Friday to procure Javelin anti-tank guided missile systems through the U.S. Foreign Military Sales route, marking a significant step in the defence partnership between the two countries.

The missile system is being bought under the emergency procurement powers granted to the armed forces to augment critical operational capabilities following Operation Sindoor, defence sources said. The Indian Army is procuring Javelin missiles in limited numbers. Under the emergency framework, the armed forces can make purchases of up to ₹300 crore for each equipment category. Deliveries of contracts under the sixth tranche of emergency procurements are expected to



The Javelin is a medium-range, anti-tank guided missile designed to engage armoured vehicles and fortified positions. AFP

begin by the end of 2026-27, sources said.

The U.S. Embassy in New Delhi welcomed the signing of the LOA, saying it demonstrated the growing depth of the U.S.-India Major Defence Partnership, and would pave the way for greater cooperation between the defence industries of the two countries. “With the signing of the LOA, India becomes a customer of the Javelin system,” the Embassy said.

U.S. Ambassador to India Sergio Gor said the agreement reflected a defence partnership that was “growing deeper, more capable, and consequential”. He said it demonstrated U.S. support for the Indian Army and created opportunities for the two countries to work together.

The Javelin is a medium-range, anti-tank guided missile designed to engage armoured vehicles and fortified positions.

Its fire-and-forget capability lets the operator fire the missile and move to another position without having to guide it throughout its flight.

The Javelin system is produced by the Javelin Joint Venture, comprising RTX and Lockheed Martin. Currently, the U.S. Army, U.S. Marine Corps and several international customers operate it. The U.S. Embassy said the signing would facilitate discussions on mutually beneficial co-production and create additional opportunities to strengthen the defence industrial bases of India and the U.S.

The procurement assumes significance in the backdrop of India's efforts to rapidly strengthen its anti-armour capabilities following Operation Sindoor, while simultaneously deepening defence-industrial cooperation with America.

INBRIEF



Schoolchildren tie *rakhi* on PM Modi on Raksha Bandhan

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday greeted people on Raksha Bandhan and expressed hope that the auspicious festival brings happiness, prosperity and success to everyone's lives. Continuing the annual tradition, schoolgirls visited the Prime Minister's official residence at 7, Lok Kalyan Marg, where they tied *rakhis* on his wrist. Mr. Modi shared photos and a video on Instagram showing the children tying *rakhis*. In the video, he was seen warmly interacting with the young visitors, shaking hands and high-fiving with them. PTI

Man electrocuted after falling into collapsed Delhi road

A 28-year-old pedestrian was electrocuted in Delhi's Surajmal Vihar after a small section of the road near an electricity pole reportedly caved in, trapping him up to his waist and bringing him into contact with a live wire, police said on Friday. The incident took place on Thursday morning when Sandeep, a caregiver, was returning home after attending to an older person. According to the preliminary enquiry, Sandeep was crossing road number 58 when the unpaved road near an electricity pole reportedly caved in. He fell into a nearly three-foot-deep pit and was trapped up to his waist. Police said electric current was passing through the lower portion of the pole, causing Sandeep to suffer a fatal electric shock. PTI

Suvendu warns against 'azadi' slogans, pledges to restore nationalism at JU

Time for final reckoning, says Bengal CM, issues stern warning to students days after clashes erupted between rival groups on campus; thousands join mass recital of *Vande Mataram* near the varsity

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Friday participated in an event near Jadavpur University (JU) where he denounced "azadi" slogans and vowed to restore the spirit of nationalism on the campus.

Mr. Adhikari was participating in a mass recital of the National Song, *Vande Mataram*, attended by thousands of people. A nearly one-km-long ramp was erected for the event.

Traffic movement along Raja Subodh Chandra Mallick Road was suspended between 1 p.m. and 6 p.m. Four gates of the university were also closed.

The visit came just a week after supporters of the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad allegedly stormed the university campus and set fire to posters put up by the Left-backed students' union on August 19. Clashes were also reported between the



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari holding the tricolour as he sings *Vande Mataram* at Jadavpur in Kolkata on Friday. ANI

rival groups. The university has set up an inquiry panel to probe the matter and multiple FIRs have been registered in connection with the incident.

"What freedom do you want? Freedom to consume heroin, ganja and drugs? Freedom for the *tukde-tukde* gang?" the Chief Minister said, denouncing slogans of "azadi (freedom)" raised by a section of students.

"What *azadi* do you want? *Kashmir Mange Azadi*?" he said.

According to the Chief Minister, students of the university took out rallies not in favour of the country but for stopping the war during Operation Sindoor. "Go write 'Free Pakistan-occupied Kashmir' first. It is ours and it must be returned," he said.

'They or we will stay'

Issuing a stern warning to the students, whom he described as "ill mannered", the CM said it is a "final reckoning". "Either they will stay, or we will. There

will be nothing in between," he said.

Mr. Adhikari also made references to Nandigram and Jangalmahal and claimed that in the past he had freed these areas of Communists and Maoists respectively. Describing himself as someone who can "clean garbage", he said, "I know the ailment and also the medicine."

He threw a challenge to the Jadavpur University Teachers' Association and said students cannot hide behind the group. He recalled an earlier visit to the university when he was the Leader of the Opposition and a student had died following an alleged case of ragging. He said some people jumped onto his vehicle and when questioned they replied: "We are Maoists. We have come to tell you to go back."

A few days ago, the Chief Minister had called for an inquiry into alleged 'anti-national' graffiti and posters that surfaced in the boys' hostel of the university's Arts unit.

Ready to resign over Statehood demand, says Puducherry CM

Rajesh B Nair
PUDUCHERRY

When the Statehood issue came up for discussion for the second consecutive day in the Puducherry Assembly on Friday, Chief Minister and AINRC founder N. Rangasamy went to the extent of offering to resign his MLA post to fight for the cause.

"I am ready to resign my MLA post, and if there is an assurance that Statehood will be given, we can go to Delhi to take up the demand with the Central government," the Chief Minister said, as members raised the issue of Statehood during the general discussion on the budget in the Assembly.

The Chief Minister's response came after BJP legislator A. John Kumar said that the demand for Statehood might not be feasible and hence, the Assembly should request the Central government to accord 'Special Category Status' to Puducherry.

'Won't try tactics'

"The BJP will try tactics with other State governments but not in Puducherry, because of the respect the BJP high command has towards our



Chief Minister N. Rangasamy

Chief Minister. The Chief Minister should go and meet the Prime Minister and make the request. If he makes the request, the Prime Minister will concede to the demand," Mr. Kumar said.

Intervening, as Mr. Kumar was speaking, Pro-tem Speaker A. Anbalagan said the BJP MLA should not create confusion as the Assembly has passed several resolutions unanimously urging the Central government to accord Statehood to Puducherry.

"The Congress and the BJP are not in favour of Statehood. The Congress, while being in power for decades at the Centre, has denied Statehood [to Puducherry] and now, the Central government headed by the BJP has made it clear several times that it is not in favour of it," Mr. Anbalagan said.

Bihar board to replace 'fail' with 'eligible for skills' on Class 10, 12 marksheets from coming year

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

The Bihar School Examination Board (BSEB) will replace "fail" in Class 10 and 12 marksheets with "eligible for skills" from next year, Education Minister Mithilesh Tiwari announced on Friday, saying failure to score the expected marks in an exam does not diminish a student's talent.

The Education Department would soon issue directives to the BSEB in this regard, he added.

"The State government wants to protect students' morale. An exam score does not define a student's overall talent or potential. So the Bihar Examination Board would state '*kaushal ke liye patra*' (eligible for skills) instead of 'fail' on their marksheets," said the Minister.

He added, "Students tak-



Education Minister Mithilesh Tiwari said failure to score expected marks does not diminish a student's talent. FILE PHOTO

ing supplementary examinations for Class 10 will receive special classes for one month to help them prepare better and to ensure success."

Many students welcomed the announcement.

"Yes, removing the word 'fail' will do a lot of good. It is such a demeaning word. There is a social taboo attached to it," said Harshu

Kumar, who is due to appear for his Class 12 exams in February next year.

Standing next to him outside a coaching centre in Patna's Kankerbagh area, another student, Ishu Kumar, termed it a "big boost" to students' morale.

The announcement comes a day after the government agreed to conduct the Teacher Recruitment Examination-4 in a single phase, following which aspirants who had been protesting in the State capital's Gardanibagh area called off their agitation.

Teacher support portal

As per sources, Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary is likely to launch a "teacher support portal" at a Teachers' Day event on September 5 in Patna, under which one teacher from each district would be honoured with a State-level award.

FIRs against Abhishek, O'Brien after scuffle over hoarding removal

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

The Kolkata police registered FIRs against Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee and Rajya Sabha MP Derek O'Brien on Friday for allegedly assaulting police and obstructing them from discharging their duty when they went to remove an electric signboard of the party at a building in Kolkata's Camac Street area. Three FIRs have been registered in connection with the scuffle.

"The removal was being done as per the direction of Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC). At least 13 people have so far been arrested in the case. All three FIRs by the police, and KMC officials have been reported at the Shakespeare police station," Additional Commissioner of Police Kunal Aggarwal said.



Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee. FILE PHOTO

Mr. Agarwal said that the accused included Derek O'Brien, Abhishek Banerjee, Humayun Kabir, Baiswanor Chattopadhyay and others.

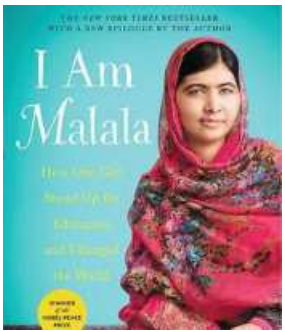
"These leaders along with their supporters, formed an unlawful assembly, obstructed and restrained the police personnel and KMC officials from entering the common area and discharging their lawful duties, and used criminal force and assault against police personnel," the officer said.

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

A reading session of Nobel Peace Prize winner Malala Yousafzai's memoir 'I Am Malala' turned violent in Gujarat's Ahmedabad city after a group of people identifying as right-wing activists attacked the participants, police said on Friday.

The police have arrested three persons in connection with the attack that occurred at Vastrapur Garden on Thursday evening, an officer said.

Vastrapur police station Inspector G.M. Chaudhary said that a group of nearly 20 people, including women, had gathered at the public garden for the reading and were confronted by an armed group of 18 to 20 individuals, claiming to be from the Bajrang Dal and Vishva Hindu Parishad



The attackers demanded to know why participants read Yousufzai's memoir. FILE PHOTO

(VHP), over their choice of book. She said that when the readers were leaving the garden after the session, around 18 to 20 people arrived at the site and angrily demanded to know why they had read Ms. Yousufzai's memoir.

An altercation ensued, leading to a scuffle in which two people were injured; the attackers were armed with sticks, the official said.

"An FIR has been registered, two of the accused were known to the victims. Apart from them, six individuals have been identified, and three have already been arrested," she said.

The attackers claimed to be affiliated with the Bajrang Dal and the VHP, she added.

A few weeks ago, a private school in Ahmedabad was forced to drop books by Ms. Yousafzai and Holocaust survivor Anne Frank from its mandatory reading list after protests from right-wing groups.

'Incurable disease'

Meanwhile, Congress leader Pawan Khera on Friday took a swipe at right-wing activists who assaulted participants of the book reading session, saying ignorance, combined with a dash of communalism, is an incurable disease.

'City of ponds': Darbhanga residents wade into legal battle to save water bodies

Amarnath Tewary
DARBHANGA (BIHAR)

Darbhangha in Bihar's Mithilanchal region, about 160 km north of State capital Patna, had over 350 ponds till 1969 as per the district gazetteer, and was known as the 'city of ponds'. Today less than 100 remain and the town is grappling with depleting groundwater, leaving residents struggling to draw water from hand pumps in summer.

The remaining ponds are allegedly being filled up daily and built over by encroachers to construct houses, hotels, hospitals and coaching institutes, according to members of Talab Bachao Abhiyan (TBA), a citizen group. They add that the State government's "rejuvenation and beautification" plan for historical ponds is deepening the water crisis.

The State Urban Development and Housing Department had entrusted BUIDCO (Bihar Urban Infrastructure Development Corporation) with a ₹70.34-crore comprehensive rejuvenation and beautification plan for three historically interconnected large ponds – Hara-hi, Dighi, and Gangasagar – covering 1.8 km. The corporation had even started work to lay pathways.

Plea in apex court

Apprehending that the plan would "alter the ecological character of the wetland system that plays a vital role in groundwater recharge, flood moderation, and biodiversity conservation", the TBA members petitioned the Supreme Court seeking restoration and reclama-

tion instead of beautification of the ponds.

They filed a writ petition on March 14 in the Supreme Court. The Division Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta recorded an oral undertaking from the Bihar government on July 28 that "no further soil would be dumped" in the three ponds and that the ongoing beautification plan will be halted thereafter. "The court also sent a clear message that ponds and water bodies cannot be encroached upon or filled under the guise of beautification," a TBA member said.

The apex court later fixed September 7 as the next date of hearing.

"We will wait for the final order of the Supreme Court in this matter and then take a decision over the allocated funds under



Work on the Bihar government's beautification plan halted at the Gangasagar pond on directions of the apex court. AMARNATH TEWARY

the scheme. Funds allocated for the beautification plan of the ponds will not go waste in any condition. In such cases, we use it for another scheme," State Urban Development and Housing Department Minister Nitish Mishra told *The Hindu* on August 26.

The TBA, formed in

2012, has about 150 members. Leading the fight are its convener Narayan Jee Choudhary, known as the 'pond man' of Darbhanga; Vidyannath Jha, a founding member who is a retired principal and Botany professor at Lalit Narayan Mithila University; and activists Taseem Nawab and

Ajit Kumar Mishra.

They allege that the beautification plan under the BUIDCO "violates the Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2017, and judicial directions governing the protection of wetlands and water bodies by the National Green Tribunal (NGT)".

'Nature's storage tanks'

According to former State Pollution Control Board chairman Ashok Kumar Ghosh, ponds are "nature's storage tanks". "During monsoon, ponds hold excess rainwater and allow it to seep into the ground, replenishing underground aquifers. Once ponds are filled and paved over, the natural recharge system is lost and rainwater flows away through drains or evaporates instead of filtering into the soil," he said.

Mr. Ghosh added that the problem has become acute with depleting groundwater in fast-growing towns like Darbhanga where demand for drinking water has led to "heavy dependence on borewells as natural recharge zones continue to disappear".

This is not the first time that the TBA has protested against encroachments. "We have organised dharnas thrice from Darbhanga to Laheriasarai, taken out rallies twice, conducted signature campaigns, and held *nukkad* (street corner) and all-party meetings to raise the issue but nothing happened. We then decided to petition the NGT, which too passed directives in our favour. Finally, we approached the apex court when the government started its beautification plan," Mr. Mishra said.

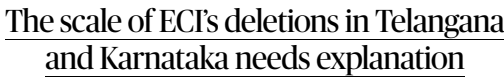
Mr. Nawab, in his 60s, claimed that he faced a "murderous attack" on January 10, 2024 for opposing encroachment of the Moin pond. He alleged that he had filed a complaint at the Laheriasarai police station on January 13, 2024, but no action was taken.

"After our legal interventions, the State government has stopped landfilling around these three ponds that are ecologically sensitive wetlands. Both the Supreme Court and the NGT have issued directions to prepare a comprehensive digital inventory of ponds and wetlands across Bihar, including Darbhanga. And by doing this, we can save these three ponds of Darbhanga as well. These directions will strengthen monitoring and conservation of ponds," Mr. Choudhary said.

Govt. track record on free coaching plan is poor: Cong.

China says collapse of glacier in Nepal likely behind flood

CM
YK



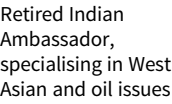
During the Bihar SIR, the Court asked why political parties had filed so few objections, seeking inclusion of wrongly deleted names; that question might hold true for the Southern States as well. A plausible reason could be that the voter id is useful to a citizen only once in a few years, leading to less alacrity on their part. This may explain why a process that puts the onus on electors yields cuts of this scale. Meanwhile, proving a smoking gun in the data is difficult because of the ECI's opacity. It has not published the elector-to-population ratio for any State so far during the revision even though doing so is mandatory and is the only test of under-enrolment. The Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer has not even bothered to release a gender-wise breakdown of the deletions, instead scattering the lists across several Google Drive links without the old booth numbers, making verification arduous. The outcome of such shoddiness is visible in West Bengal, where the ECI's dubious "logical discrepancy" process disenfranchised lakhs of electors, forcing them to seek redress before tribunals set up under the aegis of the Court. Months after the elections, records obtained under a Right to Information request show that barely 82,000 of the nearly 38 lakh appeals before the 19 tribunals have been decided, with more than 90% of those decisions favouring electors seeking restoration. The ECI – an institution once envied even by wealthier democracies for bringing large numbers of Indians to the polling booth – is now an obstacle to universal adult franchise.

Injuries are coming in the way of anticipated matchups in the US Open

However, Djokovic and Medvedev are on their own tough journeys. The 39-year-old Serb is no longer the once-renowned hard-court master, and lost his lone match – in Cincinnati – after the semifinal reverse to Sinner at Wimbledon. Medvedev was last in a Major final at the 2024 Australian Open and is without a trophy since February. Alexander Zverev thus has a golden opportunity to make his big breakthrough on his favourite surface. Without Sinner, the German will be the top seed, and following the French Open triumph and Wimbledon runner-up finish, the 29-year-old will be confidence personified. Among women, two-time defending champion Aryna Sabalenka would have liked to be that player, but the Belarusian World No. 1 has wobbled of late and seen her lead at the top cut to less than 450 points. Her chief challenger Elena Rybakina may be racing against time to recover from an ankle injury, but with Iga Swiatek, Coco Gauff and Jessica Pegula all in impressive form leading into New York, Sabalenka will have a daunting task. Wimbledon winner Linda Noskova will be looking for a worthy follow-up while the fast-rising 21-year-old from the Philippines, Alexandra Eala, will hope to continue her recent eye-popping run. With Serena and Venus Williams set to pair up in doubles, there will be a rich sprinkling of stardust too.

For a people long regarded as at the crossroads of civilisations, the past five years of the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan (IEA) under Taliban rule resemble the backwaters. After 47 years of bloodletting, terrorism and foreign occupation, the current “stability” is a respite. But the ongoing time-freeze only postpones an eventual transition to modern universality. So far, the process has been glacial and selective, causing pain and uncertainty. It is time to take stock of the past half-decade and try to fix the broad contours of a foreseeable future.

The West, in particular, felt deeply betrayed by the Taliban's cynical disregard for their commitments under the transitional accord signed in Doha in 2020 to pave the way for U.S. and North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) troop withdrawal. Two decades of the U.S. military campaign against the Taliban, which caused 6,379 deaths and cost \$2.26 trillion in expenses, now seem in vain. Despite intense Pakistani lobbying for the IEA 2.0 to be accepted and formally recognised, there was global unanimity to withhold both till such draconian policies were moderated. The global community's response to the Taliban's re-takeover was framed by the United Nations



A fortnight ago, the Taliban completed five years in power, bringing stability; but Afghans still yearn for a political, economic and social makeover

Nearly half of Afghanistan's 49 million population lives under the national poverty line, facing acute food shortages. Still, most western official development assistance (ODA) remains suspended, and many multilateral agencies restrict their funding. Some non-governmental organisations have continued to help mitigate the dire situation. The population rose by 11% in 2025, largely due to immigration. This led to a 4% decline in GDP per capita despite healthy economic growth. Afghanistan has a Human Development Index (HDI) score of 0.496, among the world's lowest. Formal unemployment is put at 13.3%, with most women and a quarter of young men jobless. While foreign trade reached \$13.9 billion in 2025, Afghan exports barely cover 15% of its imports. Despite a rise in tax revenues, negligible foreign investments and declining

During the past five years, the IEA 2.0 has sought international acceptance and legitimacy without undertaking the necessary domestic reforms. Nevertheless, the ostracising consensus has frayed, and realpolitik has spurred engagement. The IEA now claims to have 40 active diplomatic missions abroad and more than 20 countries represented in Kabul, even as Russia is so far the only country to have recognised the IEA and opened an embassy in Kabul. Pakistan, China, Iran and India have established links with Kabul at variously nuanced *de jure* levels without extending formal recognition. Some trade and mineral exploitation transactions have also been made. Iran, the Central Asian Republics, the Gulf countries and Türkiye have extended trade and logistical links. With the solitary exception of neighbouring Pakistan, with which it is in conflict, Afghanistan's links with most regional countries are stable.

As South Asia's trendsetter, India is well suited to match mutual expectations and create a pathway for normalisation of IEA 2.0, preferably through a multilateral donors' conference. Ironically, five years ago, Pakistan tried to get the world to accept the IEA 2.0. It failed because the Taliban, then flushed with victory over the U.S., saw no need to adopt. In case India decides to take up this "great game", New Delhi would need to gingerly begin at both ends. A progressive and moderate Afghanistan, thus created, would be an asset not only to India but also to the world at large.

A climate frontline

The disturbing pictures emerging from Nepal and the affected regions show the enormous destruction caused by end-glacial lake outburst floods (EGLOFs) and other extreme natural events.

Rising temperatures, melting glaciers, erratic rainfall and environmental degradation are increasing



For Nepal, India and China, the devastating cross-border floods are a stark reminder of nature's fury, and that cooperation must transcend the boundaries of geopolitics

For India, the downstream flood threats to its States have been severe, although the immediate threat from some of these events may have passed. Floodwaters reached the Gandak, Kosi and Ganga rivers in Bihar, prompting authorities in Patna to go on maximum alert and deploy large teams, particularly to the Valmikinagar Barrage and along vulnerable embankments, to monitor alarmingly high water levels. Riverside

The past few days have underscored the need to find ways to compartmentalise the harder political dynamics of the China-India-Nepal relationship and create space for cooperation when confronted with events that remind us of the fickleness of nature, the fragility of human life, and the physical interconnections that inextricably link the three countries.

the vulnerability of the Himalayan regions. Stronger climate policies, sustainable development, protection of forests and rivers, and disaster-preparedness measures are essential. Nepal and its neighbours must act collectively before nature sends even stronger warnings.

Md Sabir Hussain,
Arrah, Bihar

The devastation has exposed the vulnerability of communities living in one of the world's most fragile mountain ecosystems. It is a grim reminder of how rapidly natural disasters can turn into humanitarian catastrophes. The immediate priority must be rescue, relief and rehabilitation. Saving human lives, however,

requires moving from disaster response to disaster prevention. Countries sharing these mountains and glaciers — India, China, Pakistan, Nepal and Bhutan — should coordinate to keep people safe across borders. India and China, in particular, must demonstrate that saving human lives and protecting the environment

can transcend political differences.

Gregory Fernandes,
Mumbai

The disaster has prompted explanations, including avalanches, earthquakes, Chinese dam releases, western disturbances, intense rainfall and glacial lake outbursts. Determining the precise cause will

require rigorous scientific investigation, although political considerations and inadequate reporting may complicate the assessment. The broader lesson is clear: ecological disruption can intensify natural hazards.

R.S. Narula,
Patiala, Punjab

Letters emailed to
letters@thehindu.co.in
must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO



Senior deputy president, Kandela khap panchayat, Raghubir Bhardwaj (standing), holding a meeting with fellow members, to finalise the agenda and fix duties for the Khap Sammelan, which was held in Jind district, Haryana, on August 9. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Old rules, New rebels

Haryana's khap panchayats have issued diktats against love marriages within a village cluster or clan, and live-in and same-sex relationships. If people do not abide by these, they will be barred from entering their villages, the khaps say. This has drawn strong opposition from Gen Z on social media. A section of the youth, both women and men, say the personal choices of consenting adults trump community custom. And that laws, rather than elderly men, protect women, reports **Ashok Kumar**

Anchal, an M.A. student and a resident of Igra village, Jind district, posted a video on social media satirising khap panchayats, the powerful but unelected community bodies dominated by elderly men from landowning communities in Haryana. Imagining what a “Gen Z panchayat” might look like, she suggests in the video that elderly men face restrictions on playing cards, smoking hookahs and *bidis*, and wasting time, while tobacco sellers be fined. The money collected through such fines, she jokes, could be used to replace phones damaged or confiscated from girls.

Anchal was responding to a controversy that exploded after a khap panchayat member, Virender Dhull, a resident of Ikkas village in Haryana, made a remark about young women at the Naugama khap meeting in Jind on August 1. The comment that went viral was about women riding pillion with their fathers on two-wheelers, their legs astride, while using mobile phones and wearing clothes the khap thought unsuitable. He said their phones should be smashed. Dhull, a director of physical education at Jat Senior Secondary School in Jind, was hit by social-media criticism.

Over the past few weeks, several khap panchayats across parts of north Haryana have unleashed a series of resolutions, many against women. The khaps have opposed marriages within the community and live-in and same-sex relationships, while also resolving to fight drug abuse, online betting, and obscene social-media content.

Khap leaders insist they are not issuing diktats. They describe themselves as community elders offering guidance to the youth, and argue that their goal is to preserve social cohesion and protect families. Except, ostracisation will be a penalty for those who disregard these social rules. And the rules are targeted primarily at young women.

To many, especially the social-media-vocal Gen Z, the khaps’ message sounded like an attempt to regulate their personal choices in the name of tradition.

“Why are concerns over culture and social behaviour directed primarily at girls? If these restrictions are genuinely meant to protect society and preserve our culture, they should apply equally to men,” Anchal says.

Young women see the controversy as an enduring culture of social control over female agency, and have posted videos against the diktats. Several men too, like rapper Rahul Fazilpuria and content creator Paras Yadav, too, took to social media to condemn the resolution.

Naugama khap president, Jaivir Lohan, however, says Dhull’s remarks have been misrepresented. He maintains that the khap has not banned mobile phones for girls or prescribed what women should or shouldn’t wear. Parents, he says, should decide what is appropriate for their children, and the khap will intervene only if parents seek its help. “The views expressed during the panchayat on women’s clothing and use of mobile phones was an individual’s opinion,” Lohan says. The Naugama khap has 42 members, all male.

Haryana’s over 130 khap panchayats have long carried an image of being stuck in time. Their decisions have frequently been criticised for restrict-



Why are concerns over culture and social behaviour directed primarily at girls? If these restrictions are genuinely meant to protect society and preserve our culture, they should apply equally to men

ANCHAL
Resident, Igra village, Jind district, Haryana

ing women’s autonomy, particularly their freedom to choose whom to marry, who to associate with, and how to live. They have largely kept women away from decision-making roles.

Khap state of mind

On August 9, 24 khap panchayats met in Jind’s Kandela village. Here, they passed a resolution disallowing women and men from marrying within the same *gotra* (clan) or cluster that their khap panchayats oversee. This diktat is based on their belief that its members are one extended social family. However, people are free to choose who they marry beyond this boundary.

Chanderbhan Nambardar, a khap member, says people within this network are considered brothers and sisters, irrespective of caste differences and, in some cases, *gotra* distinctions. For the khap, therefore, a marriage within these prohibited social boundaries is seen as a relationship crossing what the community considers a kinship boundary. Lohan says that same-*gotra* marriages lead to genetic disorders and weak offspring, because of a common gene pool.

The consequences, if the khap panchayat is disobeyed, are severe. Nambardar says that if a woman and a man who come under the 24 khap panchayats disobey, they will not be allowed to enter the area under their community-appointed jurisdiction. He acknowledges that the khaps have no legal authority, though.

The khaps also passed a resolution banning live-in and same-sex relationships, and content they felt was obscene, while also urging the government to regulate marriage by choice, or love marriages, as they are called in India.

Raghubir Nain, president of the Sarvjatiya Binain khap, in Jind, says the panchayat did not oppose love marriages, but wanted them to take place with parental consent and within accepted social norms. He refers to live-in and same-sex relationships as a “*nai beemari* (new disease)” in society. The Naugama khap has made similar demands.

Naugama khap spokesperson Umed Jaglan says they want the government to examine the social consequences of live-in relationships, particularly where a married person leaves a spouse and children to live with another partner. The khap argues that such relationships can damage families and traditional social institutions.

Khap leaders also say women are being included more in decision-making now, through special assemblies and women’s wings aimed at addressing social issues.

On August 23 in Jind, the Naugama khap panchayat convened its first ever women-led mahapanchayat. They too passed resolutions against love marriages and live-in relationships, but also against dowry and gun culture. A 21-member committee will spread the word and ensure compliance.

At a mahapanchayat, held in July at the Meham Chaubisi Chabutra in Rohtak, participants adopted resolutions against drug abuse, online betting, obscene social-media content, and the glorification of guns online. The gathering also decided to eliminate the use of hookah at community functions – an especially striking move in a State where the hookah has long been a symbol of rural social interaction. The mahapanchayat was chaired by Chaubisi Khap president Subhash Goyat and attended by prominent local artists, including Ajay Hooda.

Khap leaders say these social issues they take up rarely receive the same attention as their positions on marriage and relationships. Nambardar argues the khaps are “guiding lights” for the youth.

Gen Z hits back

On her YouTube channel, Leena Sharma (leena yuvan7240) criticises what she describes the khap diktats, questioning how restrictions on women’s clothing, mobility, and behaviour can be imposed in the 21st century. She points out that women sitting astride a motorcycle is a matter of safety. She also questions khap resolutions, such as not allowing DJ music at weddings, asking why community bodies should dictate personal choices. Her larger argument is generational: cities may be changing, she says, but villages need to change too.

On Instagram, Garima (@garima.sees) talks about how the khaps were claiming that this was done to save “culture”, but it was just to control women. In a Reel with the caption “One of the reasons why Haryana is developing backwards,” she says the State grapples with one of the highest youth unemployment ratios and one of the lowest sex ratios in India. “Meanwhile, Haryana’s male youth is involved in drugs and crime, but no such panchayat is held for the betterment of these people. *Na unkey liye kuch ban kiya jaata hai, aur na unkey liye kuch rules banaye jaate hain* (Nothing for them is banned, nor are there any rules made for them),” she says on the video.

In the first four months of 2026, Haryana’s Sex Ratio at Birth plummeted to 898 girls for every 1,000 boys.

It’s not just women speaking against the diktat. Aman Kashyap, who holds a master’s degree in journalism from a university in Jind, asks, “When the Constitution grants girls equal rights, how can a panchayat decide to smash their phones or restrict their movements?” He calls these diktats illegal and contrary to fundamental rights, including the freedom of movement, expression, and privacy. He stresses that the views of a few khap members should not be seen as those of all of Haryana, noting that many students and their parents too had opposed the decisions.

Krishan Dalal, a Reel creator with nearly 27.8k followers on his Instagram account @iamkrishan7, clocked 747k views on his post on the subject. In the Reel with some mixed messaging, he says, “Actually, *ye buddhay hain gay* (Actually, these old men are gay),” adding that, “Before they die, they want to come out of the closet....” He also says, with some misunderstanding, “*Ye low testosterone mard ki pehli pehchaan hoye kare, ki jab ka-*

hin uska bas nahi chalta toh aurat ne sanskar aur sabhyachaar sikhane nikileya kare wo. (The first sign of a low-testosterone man is that when he cannot assert his authority anywhere else, he sets out to teach women about values and civilisation).”

Critics, however, point out that societal relationships are governed through individual rights and the law, rather than through community sanctions. A YouTube channel FlicksUnpacked has uploaded a Short under the title “Huge Decision by Haryana Khap on Love Marriages”. It addresses Khap members as “so-called dadajis (paternal grandfathers)”, accusing them of seeking attention and social-media fame.

The clip reflects a wider generational tension in Haryana and elsewhere: traditional community-based institutions continue to assert authority over matters of relationships and social conduct, while the youth increasingly uses digital platforms to challenge those norms and demand greater autonomy, equality, and individual rights.

Customs versus law

As they sit in a circle in a building set on 5 acres of land in Ramrai village, some of the men feel India’s laws must be in tandem with Haryana’s social customs.

“Couples entering into these relationships, which are against our social customs, are given security by law-enforcing agencies,” Jaglan says, referring to safe houses set up by the government to protect couples who have been socially ostracised and whose lives are sometimes in danger.

Jaglan says the Naugama khap has actively approached political and legal authorities seeking changes to the law. According to him, more than two years ago, a delegation first met then Haryana Chief Minister Manohar Lal Khattar, and later, in January 2025, met Union Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal. Among its demands were changes to the Hindu Marriage Act, 1955, restrictions on same-*gotra* and same-village marriages, and legal action against live-in and same-sex relationships. Jaglan says the delegation was assured that its concerns would be placed before the Union Cabinet, but that no further action or response followed.

The khap also demanded changing the legal marriage age for women, with Jaglan recalling that some members had proposed reducing it from 18 to 16. He also points to its history of approaching political and judicial authorities, including earlier meetings with former Haryana Chief Ministers Devi Lal and Bansi Lal, as well as a representation before the Supreme Court.

The khap leaders see matters such as drugs, guns, and dowry as being interconnected with other parts of the social order, like marriage and relationships. Their critics see a dangerous blurring of the line between community advice and coercion.

Anti-women accusations

Nambardar rejects the accusation that khaps are anti-women. He points to the wider political system to explain why women remain under-represented in khap leadership. “Women became sarpanches in Haryana only in the 1980s,” he says, questioning the gap between political promises and reality. “Every political party talks about 33% reservation for women, but how many women are actually in the State Assemblies and Parliament?”

According to him, the problem runs deeper than the khaps themselves. Indian society, he says, continues to be patriarchal, with women still under-represented in politics, government, and employment. “So naturally, there are fewer women in khaps as well. But their representation is growing fast.”

Nambardar argues that several decisions taken by khaps have received support from women. For instance, during the wrestlers’ protest, when several women wrestlers from Haryana had accused BJP leader Brijbhushan Singh of sexual abuse, the khaps stood by the women.

The khap remains rooted in a Haryana where village identity, kinship, honour, and collective decision-making continue to carry enormous weight. But it operates alongside Gen Z that is increasingly connected to cities, smartphones, social media, new forms of work and relationships, and a legal system built around individual rights. That collision is producing uncomfortable questions on both sides.

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Chanderbhan Nambardar with other members of the Naugama khap panchayat in Ramrai village, which oversees 21 villages in Jind district. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

MAHARASHTRA



Students at the Manjari ST Hostel in Maharashtra have been protesting in the corridors of the boys' section, with the women commuting about 4 km daily to the protest site. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

Gen Z Adivasis ask for more

In Manjari village, on the outskirts of Pune, tribal students have been protesting for over two weeks with a hunger strike against the Maharashtra government, which they say has not heard them for years. Among the 14 demands is their need for better hostel infrastructure and Supreme-Court-mandated employment assured nine years ago. **Vinaya Deshpande Pandit** speaks with the students, many of whom are first-generation college-goers



Students have been protesting for 16 days at the Manjari ST Hostel on the outskirts of Pune city, seeking safety, health, and better educational quality and infrastructure. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

As the media cameras hover over a youth group of 70-80 students, men on the left and women on the right, they lash out at the booms: “The government should feel ashamed! Its young generation has been suffering silently, raising demands in a democratic manner. And what are they doing? Ignoring our voices. The Adivasi will not be silent now. We are the children of Birsa Munda,” says a youth, his fists clasped. “There will be consequences if anything happens to our brothers and sisters who have been on a hunger strike,” says another young woman.

A group of medical staff intervene as they check the vital parameters of the students lying down at the Manjari ST (Scheduled Tribes) Hostel on the outskirts of Pune, Maharashtra. Sleeping on cotton mattresses, covered in dusty blankets, these students on a hunger strike, gather all the energy when questions are posed to them.

A group of students sits around their heads, whispering in their ears about the delegation which has left to speak with the government. The blue table fans are tilted horizontally, to give relief to the students lying down, weak from not eating for 14 days.

Other protesters are busy checking their social media feed. Some live stream the protest on their personal social media handles. A public announcement system is in use almost all the time, motivating the students to fight for their rights.

At the hostel are posters of Dalit icon Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, the 19th-century educator-social reformer Savitribai Phule, and the 19th-century social reformer Chhatrapati Shahu Maharaj. One is of Birsa Munda, the tribal leader the young woman referred to, who fought for indigenous rights. The government celebrated his 150th birth anniversary in 2025 with much ado.

Tribal students have been protesting from August 12-13 in at least 25 parts of Maharashtra, to draw the government's attention to their long-pending demands. These include the filling up of 12,500 government-job positions for tribals, as directed by the Supreme Court in 2017; better living conditions, kitchens, and reading rooms in hostels; improved and expanded educational facilities and infrastructure.

The government has held four rounds of talks with the protesters in Manjari. The students have a list of 14 demands. First, the government accepted one, suspending the clause of age limit for admission to the tribal government hostels.

On August 28, as the protest entered its 16th day and political mobilisation grew, Maharashtra's Tribal Affairs Minister, Ashok Uike, told students that the government has accepted all their demands. The students say they will withdraw the agitation once they receive the written draft of the government's assurances.

Hunger caused a strike

Hung from the ceiling in the corridor where the protest is taking place, are effigies of tamasha



We have sat for these protests for the last four years, ever since I entered the hostel. Why do we have to protest every year to make ourselves heard, to get basic concerns like safety and hygiene addressed?

GAURI PARDHI
A student in the Manjari ST Hostel

performers, legs dangling overhead. Tamasha is a local folk dance, and is also a word used pejoratively in Marathi to refer to drama. The protesters, most in their 20s, have put them up satirising what a senior administrative officer said. “Stop your tamasha,” he told us. So we hung these here, to tell him that we won't,” says a woman.

The narrow lane leading to the three buildings of the government-run tribal boys' hostel on the outskirts of Pune has been unusually abuzz with activity since Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's Pune visit. In his 'Chhatron ki Goonj' (Resonating Sounds of Students) rally held on August 22, he gave the protesting students a platform to speak, thereafter writing a letter to Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, asking him to address the concerns of the students. It was after this that the age cut-off in hostels was removed.

Women come to the protest site daily, commuting about 4 km from the girls' hostel. Sometimes there may not be electricity or water; sometimes the bus is delayed.

Bustle in the lanes

Outside the narrow lane of the hostel, police *bando* (arrangement) has increased. So has the footfall. Several political parties and social organisations have visited to express their support. When political parties' delegations give lofty promises of support, the girls quickly seek their names and contact details.

The residents of the buildings around the hostel in the residential area are piqued by the rise in social interest. Standing around the muddy ditches in the lane, they whisper to each other about the flow of visitors.

As a doctor from the nearby Loni Kalbhor Public Health Centre checks the blood sugar and

blood pressure levels of the agitating students, 26-year-old Shweta Irnak shrieks, her body convulsing. The doctor is unable to draw blood from her fingertips for a routine blood sugar level test. “They have pricked all my fingers. I can't take it anymore,” she says, as the doctor announces that she needs to be moved to the hospital immediately.

“Their condition is critical. Shweta needs immediate medical attention. We have already evacuated Nikita Mechikar to the health centre,” says Dr. Manoj Thawre. Of the six tribal students on a hunger strike in Manjari, Shweta is the second and the only girl at the protest site now. Nikita is under medical supervision at the Loni Kalbhor Primary Health Centre after she refused to go to a larger medical facility, Sassoon Hospital, about 15 kilometres away.

The medical team says that the blood pressure of all the protesting students has dropped; so has their blood sugar level. “But we are giving them only symptomatic treatment as they have refused to take any medicines. We administer IV fluids, but they come back to the protest site,” he says. A nurse on rotation duty writes down the vital parameters of all the students on a chart.

For Nikita Mechikar, Shweta Irnak, Sharad Thokal, Rajaram Padvi, Vijay Bamble, and Rahul Dhanve, their hunger strike is a mission to force the government to hear their voices. These tribal youth from different parts of Maharashtra are united by their resolve not to give up.

First-generation learners

The immediate trigger for the protest this year was the government order issued on August 5, which capped the age limit for stay in the tribal hostels at 26 years. Several students say the hostel gives them the place to study for competitive exams and apply for jobs in the city, so that they can eventually stand on their own feet.

Tribal organisations and students' unions gave a memorandum to the government, seeking that the age limit be scrapped. After protests started in different parts of Maharashtra, the government issued a fresh order on August 14.

In this order, they increased the age limit to 30 years. By this time, the protests had already begun, and were fuelled by the death of three tribal girls from snake bite at a private aided tribal ashram school in Gadchiroli. The protesters demanded that the families of these girls receive compensation of ₹1 crore. They also asked for health insurance.

“There is so much competition in education, in jobs. Several of us are the first generation in our families to go for higher education. We don't have any resources to stay in big cities, to find jobs,” says 21-year-old Gauri Pardhi from Junnar, a taluka in Pune district. Sitting at the protest site, she talks about how her younger brother is also a part of a similar protest in Ghodegaon, about 75 km away.

The government scrapped the age limit, but

Vijay Waghmare, Secretary, Tribal Development Department, says the original intent of putting an age cap for stay in hostels, was to give younger tribal girls the opportunity to come and study in large cities.

“The younger tribal students need more sheltering and a sense of community belonging when they leave their house at the age of 18. The older tribal students will continue to be supported through the Swayam Scholarship scheme until they turn 30,” he says. This is specifically for those who do not get hostel accommodation.

The students say that the state needs to build capacity to absorb more tribals in hostels. “For several years, the government has not increased the number of tribal hostels or the number of students who can be accommodated in them. Give us opportunities to study. Build more hostels,” says Navnath More, a protester.

Many complain that ST hostels are often at the edges of cities, making commute time to colleges long and difficult. They want hostels within cities.

According to the state government, 59,020 students stay in 490 tribal hostels in Maharashtra.

A reiteration of needs

Among the list of demands the tribal students have made, is the withdrawal of Government Resolutions that restrict student assembly, protests, and union participation. They have also sought an immediate halt to invasive and compulsory medical practices, such as pregnancy tests in female tribal hostels, and have demanded better security for students.

“Most of these demands have been made each year. We have sat for these protests for the last four years, ever since I entered the hostel. Why do we have to protest every year to make ourselves heard, to get basic concerns like safety and hygiene addressed?” asks Pardhi.

Students also want the central kitchens which supply food shut, so fresh food is cooked at each tribal school location. “The tribal ashram schools are located far apart. Often, the food is cooked several hours before, and transported up to 100 km. There are times it goes bad. The children stay hungry,” says Suchitra Pagl, also on protest.

Government officials say central kitchens are easier to monitor. “Quality control becomes easier. Local level complaints of bad food are avoided. This is a tried and tested model,” an official of the Tribal Department says. For the tribal students studying in colleges, the protesters want the government to halt the Direct Benefit Transfer money and provide messes in each hostel instead.

On the filling of job vacancies, a government official says, “It is not something that can be done overnight. Our talks are on. We will find a way to handle this, but many departments are involved.” Minister Uike told the protesters that he would discuss the issue with the Chief Minister and find a resolution.

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KERALAM



Differently abled children and their parents need a lifetime of support. K. RAGESH

Braving the odds

Even after a decade of passing the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, the plight of the parents of differently abled individuals continues.

A.S. Jayanth meets some of the parents to document their struggles

A dilemma rattled Rani Mahesh*, a native of Koyilandy in Keralam’s Kozhikode, when her husband was admitted to a private medical college hospital in the district for treatment a few years ago. She wanted to be with him. But her only child, who has cerebral palsy, could not be left alone at home.

“Worried about who would look after her, I couldn’t stop crying on the bus while going back home from the hospital that day. As suggested by a friend, I decided to take my child to a privately run care home for differently abled children in my home town. But I was not familiar with the place then,” she says.

Help came in the form of P.K. Jameela* from Malappuram, who volunteered to take care of the child there.

“She understood my anxiety because her child too was differently abled. She attended to my daughter’s needs along with her own child for over 40 days,” says Rani. She is among the many parents in Keralam whose lives are inseparably linked with that of their children. But their concerns rarely get the attention they deserve, according to them. K. N. Roshan Bijlee, director, Composite Regional Centre for Skill Development, Rehabilitation and Empowerment of Persons With Disabilities (CRC), a network of nodal institutions set up by the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities, Ministry of Social Justice in Kozhikode, points out that every such parent goes through different stages of grief.

“There is denial of reality; anger or frustration either at oneself or others; an attempt to get out of the situation; a period of sadness or depression; and finally the acceptance of reality,” he says. Roshan claims that there have also been episodes of men deserting their wives after blaming them for the child’s condition.

Worried about future

As the child grows up, the nature of the challenges also changes. “The child can somehow clear Class XII with the help of a scribe. But most parents will then be worried about their future as adults. In the past year alone, there have been over 20 cases of such parents either trying to kill their adult children or attempting to end their lives in Keralam. ‘What will happen to my child after my life’ is their biggest concern,” he says.

Around 34% of the parents of girls are worried about the safety and well-being of their children in their absence. Menstrual hygiene management is another challenge, leading to increased physical and mental fatigue. Sleeplessness is common.

There are also instances of social stigma as attempts are made to keep differently abled children away from events such as weddings. Such attitudes affect the parents, Roshan says. D. K. Babu, a retired college teacher in Kozhikode, whose son is differently abled, agrees with this.

“It has been only a decade since Parliament passed the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act to protect the dignity, rights, and inclusion of differently abled individuals. Society needs to accept the fact that most of them cannot survive without their parents’ help,” he notes.

Babu is part of an association of parents for the rehabilitation and assistance for differently

There are many government projects and schemes for the differently abled. We need to ensure that they are reaching the intended beneficiaries

T. K. MUHAMMAD YUNUS
General secretary of a private care home

abled individuals. Social activists say that the parents, especially the mothers, are often forced to give up their higher studies, careers, and social lives altogether. A recent survey conducted by a private care home centre among a select group of 200 parents shows that there are at least four PhD holders, one of them from an Indian Institute of Technology, and 30 postgraduate degree holders, who are unable to pursue a career for themselves. Most of them were avoiding social events too.

U. Nandakumar, former Professor of Physical Medicine and Rehabilitation, Sree Chitra Tirunal Institute for Medical Sciences and Technology, Thiruvananthapuram, meanwhile, says there still exists a conservative section in Keralam that blames the mothers for their children’s condition.

‘Magical cures’

“The mothers are always forced to carry the care-giving burden. This could lead to fatigue and mental breakdown because there may not be many with whom they can share their worries. Also, many parents of differently abled children are reported to be falling prey to people who offer magical cures. They even sell their properties falsely believing that their child will get better. However, such treatment will only hurt the children,” he says.

T. K. Muhammed Yunus, general secretary of a private care home in Kozhikode and convener of the local-level committee of National Trust of India, a statutory body chaired by the District Collector, feels the need to financially empower the parents, who also need mental health support.

“There are many government projects and schemes for the differently abled. We need to en-

sure that they are reaching the intended beneficiaries. We have enough institutions and laws, but they need to be made more effective. Launching new projects is not the solution; empowering the existing ones is. For example, there is a provision for pension for differently abled people. But how many are getting it and how many are left out—such things need to be streamlined,” he says.

Need for follow-up

Most often, projects are launched and schemes are announced, but there is no proper follow-up or evaluation, he feels. Yunus suggests a convergence between the Departments of Education, Health, and Social Justice to solve the concerns. “A start can be made by including their real-life problems in the school curriculum, which otherwise gives information only about success stories,” he says.

Recently, a collective of parents for the rehabilitation and assistance for differently abled individuals had launched a community living space at Keezhariyur in Kozhikode to help their children stand on their own feet.

The parents pooled in money to buy land. They are planning to construct 25 houses of 800 sq. ft. area each on the campus. The work on five houses is over. Vocational training centres, therapy units, classrooms, dormitories, common kitchen, recreational parks, turf ground, and a health centre too are in the pipeline. The idea is to have a space where people with intellectual disabilities can live even in the absence of their parents, according to those at the collective.

“The children can stay with their parents in their houses and also in the dormitories. This is to give them an experience of self-reliance,” K. Koyatty, the trust chairperson, says.

Roshan highlights the need for a lifetime of support for the parents at varying stages of the growth of their children.

“Unfortunately, many parents remain unaware of the different milestones of brain development, identification of issues, and proper intervention, especially for neurological disorders. At least some of them don’t know what medical methods are available to detect the various types of disability and the therapies available,” he says.

A Social Justice department official, who preferred not to be quoted, claims that the existing policy itself is “parent-centric”.

Government initiatives

Besides private institutions, there are a few government initiatives in northern Kerala, including the Regional Intervention Centre sand Autism Centre attached to the Government Medical College Hospital, Kozhikode, and the District Early Intervention Centre at the Government General Hospital, Kozhikode. At the regional level, there are community-based disability management centres attached to primary health centres. However, he admits that other districts may not have many such facilities. The organisations of parents of children with intellectual and developmental disabilities are also actively working in the sector.

Roshan says that many outreach programmes are being held under the CRC to connect with the parents. “We have one section for those aged up to six and another for those aged above six. There are departments for physiotherapy, occupational therapy, clinical psychology, physical medicine, speech and hearing, audiology, and special education. There is a comprehensive system,” he adds.

A.K. Abdul Hakeem, a former Samagra Shiksha Keralam (SSK) official involved in the design of projects for differently abled students, suggests setting up a social security system in the public sector to address the parents’ concerns.

“The problem is more severe for those aged above 18. We need to have schemes to convert their physical or intellectual disability as an advantage. For example, people with intellectual disabilities could be deployed for jobs that are mechanical in nature after they are properly trained,” he says.

Addressing the demand from social activists to set up respite care centres in districts for providing temporary accommodation to differently abled people so that the caregivers can attend to emergencies, medical treatment, travel, or social events, the Social Justice department earlier in August declared the launch of three ‘Anpu’ homes in the State.

The differently abled people and their parents can stay for up to seven days there. One beneficiary can make use of the facility twice in six months. At a time, 25 to 30 people will be admitted.

“Each scheme or project gives hope for these people. The government should first ensure that the end-result is positive,” Yunus suggests.

Rani found a pillar of support in Jameela. But most people are not that lucky. “I can only wish I will get similar help when I need it,” Jameela sighs.

(*names changed to protect their privacy).



There are many outreach programmes being held under the Composite Regional Centre for Skill Development, Rehabilitation and Empowerment of Persons With Disabilities to connect with the parents of differently abled children. K. RAGESH

ANDHRA PRADESH



A hard row to hoe: Farmers resort to laying temporary PVC pipelines across dry fields to draw distant ground water and irrigate the soil ahead of sowing. K.V.S. GIRI

Amid rain deficit, farmers in State have hard choices to make

From parched drylands in Bapatla to diesel-powered pumps in the Krishna Delta and rotting paddy fields in West Godavari, farmers in Andhra Pradesh are confronting different faces of the same climate crisis during the ongoing Kharif season, writes **G.V.R. Subba Rao**

By late August, the earth in Inagallu village of Bapatla district should be shimmering with the emerald green of young Bengal gram shoots. Instead, Kommineni Srinivasa Rao walks across a vast expanse of hard, cracked soil where his plough refuses to bite. For Srinivasa Rao, who owns four acres of land and leases six more, the 2026 monsoon has been a harsh reality check. His days are now an anxious vigil under a cloudless sky, leaving him apprehensive about spending his last borrowed funds – a final gamble on a harvest that may never yield a single grain. Across Andhra Pradesh, Srinivasa Rao’s nightmare is repeating on a mass scale, turning a routine agricultural season into a desperate financial survival test because of water scarcity, shrinking or delayed crop coverage, and relentlessly rising cultivation costs.

For thousands of farming families across the State, the primary worry is no longer about which crop will fetch a good price in the market. Instead, the questions are whether they can plant anything at all? What crops can survive with dwindling water supply? Or whether their harvests will ever cover their mounting debts?

“If there are no rains, we cannot even plough the land properly. We ploughed once when there was some moisture, but the soil has dried up again [this Kharif season]. Everything has come to a standstill,” Srinivasa Rao says.

There is also a psychological dimension to the crisis, says Srinivasa Rao. Farming, he says, is a seasonal occupation built around hope. A farmer prepares the land in anticipation of rain and watches the sky while deciding whether to sow. When the monsoon behaves unpredictably, every decision becomes a gamble.

“We [farmers] keep waiting for the next rain before deciding what to do. We have to think about whether to sow, whether to spend more money and whether the crop will survive,” he says.

Dilemma of crop diversification

Caught between erratic weather and spiralling financial risks, farmers in the State face a harsh reality. Although the State government’s advice to switch from water-hungry paddy to drought-hardy crops sounds good on paper, it ignores the heavy debts and rigid system tied to traditional farming. For farmers accustomed to paddy cultivation, the decision is not so simple. Paddy is not merely another crop. It is a familiar agricultural system with established seed supply, cultivation practices, labour arrangements, procurement channels and marketing mechanisms. When farmers are asked to shift to red gram, black gram, green gram, castor, millets or other crops, they are effectively being asked to reorganise their entire agricultural plan.

In the dryland belt around Kottur mandal in the Bapatla district, where nearly 3,800 acres depend largely on rainfall, agriculture has virtually

If there are no rains, we cannot even plough the land properly. We ploughed once when there was some moisture, but the soil has dried up again [this Kharif season]. Everything has come to a standstill

KOMMINENI SRINIVASA RAO
A farmer

come to a halt. Tobacco, once an important commercial crop, has lost much of its attraction because of weak demand and market uncertainty. Chilli cultivation has shrunk to barely 100 to 150 acres, constrained by water scarcity and soaring input costs.

Farmers are now pinning their hopes on Bengal gram, which can still be sown in November or December, if the rains return. But even this represents a gamble. A delayed shift to an alternative crop can mean fresh expenditure on seed and land preparation, without any certainty over weather or prices.

Three-front climate crisis

The 2026 Kharif season is pushing Andhra Pradesh’s agricultural sector to its absolute limits. Agriculture supports nearly 62% of the state’s population, making rural livelihoods a primary focus for the administration, especially after the state recorded a massive foodgrain production of 237 lakh metric tonnes the previous year. However, El Niño conditions have severely disrupted the monsoon.

With an extreme 51% monsoon shortfall paralysing agriculture across the State, cultivators are forced to spend more money to keep failing crops alive. Without immediate financial relief and systemic support, rural communities are running out of both water and the financial capacity to wait for help.

Agriculture Director Dr. Manazir Jeelani Samoon says the broader crisis is reflected in Andhra Pradesh’s alarming rainfall situation, with El Niño conditions severely disrupting the 2026 Kharif monsoon. “While the country as a whole recorded a 13% monsoon deficit between June 1 and August 25, Andhra Pradesh registered an extreme 51% rainfall shortfall,” Samoon says. “All 28 districts in the State are in deficit, with 25 classified as deficit and three as large-deficit.”

“The State has brought 20.35 lakh hectares under cultivation so far, compared with 25.63



Agricultural workers spraying pesticides over standing paddy fields to protect the crop from pest infestations; (below) farm labourers transplanting paddy saplings in waterlogged fields. K.V.S. GIRI

lakh hectares during the corresponding period last year. However, this should not be seen merely as a decline in agricultural activity,” Samoon says, adding, “The cropping pattern reflects a planned, water-budgeted shift towards pulses and other drought-resilient crops in areas where paddy cultivation is not viable because of limited water availability.”

Consequently, sowing has lagged far behind normal levels. By August 19, according to former Andhra Pradesh State Agriculture Mission vice-chairman Y.V.S. Nagi Reddy, Kharif sowing covered only 18.9 lakh hectares, about 61% of the normal target of 30.84 lakh hectares. Major rain-fed crops like groundnut have been hit hardest, with sowing reaching only 34% of normal areas.

Coverage for other staple crops stands at 62% for paddy, 70% for pulses, 75% for cotton, and 61% for maize.

The impact has been particularly severe in the rain-fed districts of Anantapur, Sri Sathya Sai, Kurnool, Nandyal, YSR Kadapa and Palnadu, where farmers who sowed after receiving early rains in June subsequently faced prolonged dry spells. In Kothapalli village of Krishna district, M. Venkateswara Rao points out that delayed canal releases have forced cultivators into a desperate, costly struggle. With canal supplies inadequate, farmers rely heavily on diesel-powered engines and motors to lift water. Operating these pumps consumes between 10 and 15 litres of diesel per hour, sharply inflating cultivation costs. For tenant

farmers, diesel expenses alone add roughly ₹15,000 to their seasonal burden. Furthermore, delayed water releases pushed paddy transplantation back by over 20 days, encouraging weed growth and forcing additional manual labour expenses.

Further north, in West Godavari district’s Malavaram Lanka, tenant farmer Kavuru Srinivasa Rao watched his newly transplanted paddy rot within 10 days due to collar rot and root decay. Forced to clear the field and replant entirely, the second transplantation added an estimated ₹6,000 per acre, driving total seasonal expenses from ₹35,000 up to ₹45,000 per acre. “We had to clear the field and transplant a second time,” he says. The narrow window to replant has also pushed up labour costs. Farmers have complained of delays and technical difficulties in accessing fertilizers through digital distribution systems, forcing some to approach private dealers, where they allege prices are higher.

The burden on tenant farmers

For tenant farmers, there is little room to absorb such shocks. Without recognised documents proving cultivation rights, many find it difficult to access institutional credit, crop insurance and government compensation. Emergency expenditure on replanting, pesticide sprays and labour is therefore financed through informal loans carrying monthly interest rates of 2% to 3%.

This is why the present crisis is not merely about rainfall statistics or the area brought under cultivation. It is also about the cost of adaptation.

A farmer who does not sow paddy because of a water shortage may avoid one risk, but may still face another if alternative crops fail to receive adequate rainfall or do not fetch remunerative prices. A farmer who has already transplanted paddy may have no option but to spend more money pumping water. And one whose crop fails may have to invest again to remain in cultivation.

The Andhra Pradesh Tenant Farmers’ Association secretary Maganti Haribabu opines that the government should immediately declare drought-affected mandals and provide a comprehensive relief package. Sought a compensation of at least Rs.10,000 an acre for farmers and tenant cultivators who have suffered crop losses or have been unable to cultivate.

Nagi Reddy has gone a step further, calling for an “agricultural emergency”.

Farmers’ organisations have demanded emergency irrigation support, uninterrupted power for agricultural pumping, crop-loss assessment, loan relief, and expanded employment support for agricultural labourers. They have also raised a fundamental issue that has long remained unresolved in Andhra Pradesh agriculture.

While landowners may have documents, access to banks and eligibility for government schemes, the person actually cultivating the crop can remain invisible in official records. The association alleges that in several cases, actual cultivators are not being properly recorded in e-crop data, depriving them of insurance, compensation, institutional credit and other assistance.

For farmers like Srinivasa Rao in Bapatla, the immediate question is simple: When will it rain?

For tenant cultivators in Krishna, it is: When will water reach the fields?

And for farmers struggling to save replanted crops in West Godavari, the question is whether the crop will survive long enough to recover even a part of the money already spent. The 2026 Kharif season is therefore becoming a season of hard choices. Farmers are being asked to use less water but often spend more, grow alternative crops but accept unfamiliar risks, and adapt to climate uncertainty while carrying the burden of old debts and new investments. One farmer waits for rain, another for canal water and a third for a damaged crop to recover. But all are caught in the same cycle of uncertainty – water scarcity, rising costs and mounting debt.



CM
YK

ISLAMABAD
Iftikhar Gillani, of ruling PML-N, elected as PoK ‘Prime Minister’



▲ Barrister Iftikhar Ali Gillani was on Friday elected to the post of ‘Prime Minister’ of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) following recent elections marred by violent protests and allegations of massive rigging. Mr. Gillani, of the ruling Pakistan Muslim League Nawaz, secured 30 of the 44 votes in the legislative assembly. PTI

KYIV
Russian drones batter Ukraine’s Kyiv region for the second day



▲ Russian forces on Friday resumed their drone barrage of Ukraine’s Kyiv region, firing 164 drones, and hit more than a dozen apartment buildings and storage depots in a second straight day of aerial attacks, officials said. The attacks killed one person and wounded two others, according to officials. AP

SAN FRANCISCO
U.S. federal court rules Pentagon ban of AI giant Anthropic unlawful



▲ A U.S. federal judge ruled on Thursday that sanctions imposed by the Trump administration against AI giant Anthropic were illegal, finding that the government punished the company in a row over military use of its technology. “The empty invocation of national security is not a blank check to punish government critics.” AFP

OSLO
Norway’s King Harald V dies at 89; his son becomes King Haakon VIII



▲ Norway’s King Harald died on Friday aged 89, the palace said, and amidst widespread mourning and tributes his 53-year-old son Haakon immediately succeeded him on the throne. Haakon, who announced he would reign under the name King Haakon VIII, takes over a monarchy long hailed for its modernity and modesty. AFP

Dhaka ‘positively’ weighs joining Mecca Pact

BNP-led government says the interests of the country and its people would be given the highest priority in joining any defence agreement or alliance; Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman says Bangladesh’s accession is not currently under discussion and that it has not received any formal proposal yet; major Opposition parties voice support

Rabiul Alam
DHAKA

Bangladesh will give positive consideration to joining the Mecca Pact, the trilateral defence agreement signed by Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan, should its members propose bringing Dhaka into the framework, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Dr. Khalilur Rahman told Parliament on Thursday. The BNP-led government’s such consideration has also drawn support from the country’s main Opposition parties, including Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami and the National Citizen Party (NCP).

Responding to a supplementary question from Independent Member of Parliament Rumin Farhana

during the third session of the 13th Parliament, Mr. Rahman said Bangladesh’s accession to the pact was not currently under discussion and would depend on the intentions of the agreement’s existing signatories. “If they express interest in bringing Bangladesh into this pact, the government will certainly consider it positively,” he said.

Ms. Farhana had asked what benefits Bangladesh stood to gain from joining the pact, signed on August 7, and whether Dhaka intended to do so.

Mr. Rahman said the government viewed the agreement, struck between the three countries, as a positive development, but that the question of Bangladesh’s membership had “not yet arisen,” since



Khalilur Rahman says Dhaka’s accession to the pact would depend on the intentions of the agreement’s existing signatories. AFP

no formal proposal had been extended.

“The time has not yet come to weigh the pros and cons of the pact before a proposal for Bangladesh’s inclusion is made,” he said, adding that the government would take all aspects into account if and when such a proposal materialised.

“We will certainly keep all these matters under consideration,” the Minister said.

Mr. Rahman also suggested the pact could, if expanded further, evolve into a collective self-defence

mechanism for the wider Muslim world.

“This is our family. This is an internal matter of the Muslim family. Others need not be concerned about it.”

Replying to another supplementary question from Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami lawmaker Mir Ahmad Bin Quasem, the Foreign Minister also said Bangladesh would use its presidency of the United Nations General Assembly to serve all 193 member states rather than pursue the interests of any particular country.

Swift endorsement

The government’s such move draws swift endorsement from the key Opposition parties. Dr. Shafiqur Rahman, Leader of the Op-

position in Parliament and Ameer of Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami, said on Thursday that any decision to join the Mecca Pact is entirely Bangladesh’s own affair.

“If Bangladesh makes a decision in the interests and for the needs of the country and its people, there is no reason for anyone else to feel suffocated by it,” he added.

The National Citizen Party (NCP) went further, welcoming the possibility of Bangladesh’s entry outright. In a press release on Wednesday, the party said the pact could open avenues for political and military coordination and cooperation in defence technology, strengthening Bangladesh’s security, trade and strategic ties

with key countries in the Muslim world.

The party cautioned, however, that any decision to join a collective defence framework should rest on a comprehensive assessment of the country’s long-term national interests, security and strategic capabilities, rather than on political considerations or immediate diplomatic calculations.

The Mecca Joint Defence Agreement was signed in the Saudi city by Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, establishing a mutual-defence clause under which an attack on any one signatory would be treated as an attack on all three.

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran left the door open to diplomacy on Friday, six months into a war with the United States that has upended the West Asia, but only if Washington abandons its pressure campaign.

“Putting diplomacy back on track isn’t impossible. It hinges on U.S. understanding of one simple fact: pressure doesn’t work,” Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi posted on X on Friday.

In the latest effort to reinvigorate diplomacy, Mr. Araghchi met his Qatari counterpart on Thursday in Tehran to discuss the Strait of Hormuz, closed by the Islamic republic at the start of the war.

China removes two high-ranking officers from military body

Agence France-Presse
BEIJING

China removed two high-ranking officers from the country’s main military body on Friday, state media reported, seven months after it was announced that Zhang Youxia and Liu Zhenli were being investigated for “serious violations of the law”.

Mr. Zhang’s position as the more senior of two vice chairmen on the Central Military Commission (CMC) had made him China’s highest-ranked general.

In January though, the Defence Ministry said that Mr. Zhang and Mr. Liu were “suspected of serious

violations of discipline and the law”, a common euphemism for corruption.

The announcement fit into the sweeping anti-graft drive that has defined President Xi Jinping’s time in power.

On Friday, state news agency *Xinhua* said in a report on a meeting of the standing committee of China’s Parliament that “the meeting decided to remove Zhang Youxia from the post of Vice Chairman of the Central Military Commission of the People’s Republic of China”.

Mr. Liu, who was chief of staff of the CMC’s joint staff department, which oversees combat planning, was also removed, it said.

Choice of the masses



United voices: A participant waves an Icelandic flag during a rally of supporters of the ‘No’ campaign against reopening the country’s European Union accession negotiations in Reykjavik, Iceland on Thursday, two days ahead of a national referendum. AFP

Syria’s Sharaa names Kurdish leader Abdi as presidential adviser

Agence France-Presse
DAMASCUS

Syrian President Ahmed al-Sharaa appointed Kurdish leader Mazloum Abdi as a presidential adviser, state media said on Friday, days after Mr. Abdi announced the dissolution of his Kurdish forces under an integration deal with Damascus.

The Education Ministry also published a decision authorising Kurdish-language instruction in public and private schools.

“Mustafa Khalil Abdi is appointed as adviser to the presidency of the republic,” announced the decree, signed by Mr. Sharaa and published by state



Mazloum Abdi news agency SANA.

Mr. Abdi, who has been known by several different names, was for years the leader of the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF), the Washington-backed group at the forefront of the battle against the Islamic State jihadist group.

U.S. President announces new ‘Space Academy’

Agence France-Presse
JOHNSON SPACE CENTER

President Donald Trump on Friday announced the creation of a “Space Academy” to train future civilian and military recruits for an arena where the United States faces rivalry with China.

Speaking at NASA’s Johnson Space Center in Houston, Mr. Trump said the institution would be modelled on the famed U.S. military academy at West Point.

“It’s called the U.S. Space Academy. That’s a big deal,” he said as he signed an executive order creating the new school.

Civil rights rally targets voting changes pushed by Trump ahead of Nov. polls

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

Civil rights activists gathered in Washington on Friday in a major show of opposition to restrictions on voting being pushed by President Donald Trump and Republican redistricting ahead of November’s U.S. midterm elections.

The “Defend the Vote” march brought protesters to the National Mall 63 years to the day after Martin Luther King Jr. delivered his “I Have a Dream” speech during the landmark 1963 March on Washington.

Organised by veteran civil rights leader Al Sharpton and led by King’s son Martin Luther King III, the



People attend the ‘Defend the Vote’ rally and march for voting rights, at the Lincoln Memorial in Washington on Friday. REUTERS

demonstration was expected to draw support from more than 90 civil rights, labour, faith and community organisations.

Prominent speakers include left-wing Senator Bernie Sanders and Democratic congresswoman Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez.

“Defending the vote means defending the foundation of our democracy. Sixty three years after my father stood at the Lincoln Memorial, we are called to march again, not only in remembrance, but in ac-

tion,” Mr. King III said ahead of the event.

Organisers say voting rights are under their most serious threat in decades following a Supreme Court ruling in April that weakened protections under the landmark 1965 Voting Rights Act.

The decision cleared the way for Republican-led states in the South to redraw congressional districts in ways civil rights groups say dilute the political influence of Black voters.

Civil rights organisations have challenged Mr. Trump’s executive order, while courts have issued a rapid series of conflicting decisions over how much of it can take effect.

Israel says it killed 3 ‘ Hamas’ militants in West Bank strike

Agence France-Presse
JENIN

The Israeli military said it struck and killed three militants on Friday in the occupied West Bank, a rare air strike in the Palestinian territory that has seen growing tension.

“Three terrorists eliminated in the Jenin area,” the Israeli military said, naming one as Qais Bitawi, whom it described as a Hamas operative in a dismantled Jenin militant network.

The Palestinian Health Ministry said it had been informed of the death of three men in their 20s, including 22-year-old Bitawi, after they were “targeted by a drone” in Jenin, ad-



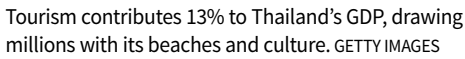
Members of the Israeli forces inspect a body as they stand in an area following an air strike in the West Bank city of Jenin on Friday. AP

ding that their bodies were being withheld.

In a statement, Hamas denounced the strike.

Hamas’s armed wing, the Ezzedine Al-Qassam Brigades, said Bitawi was one of its commanders, adding he was killed “following a cowardly assassination operation... alongside his fellow martyrs”.

The armed wing of Palestinian Islamic Jihad, however, said in a statement that Bitawi and the two others killed were its fighters.



Agence France-Presse
BANGKOK

However, experts warn the country needs to balance tighter oversight with its reliance on tourism, which accounts for 13% of GDP.

Associated Press
HONG KONG

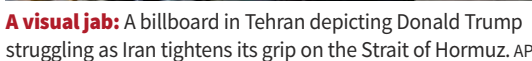
Lee Cheuk-yan (centre), along with Chow Hang-tung, and Albert Ho was convicted of inciting subversion under China's security law. AP

The disbanded alliance was best known for organising the only large-scale public commemoration in China that drew tens of thousands of people an-

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

As the conflict grinds on, Mr. Trump's talk of

But Mr. Trump has bristled at suggestions that this



Mr. Trump's war has stretched on far longer than he told Americans it

Iranian officials have said the country has suffered \$270 billion in direct and indirect damage. Israeli military strikes in the first weeks of the war wiped out

A motorcyclist crosses a railway line just as a commuter train arrives at a station in Kibera settlement in Nairobi, Kenya, on Friday. REUTERS

In a poll conducted in March, nearly eight out of 10 Norwegians felt that he would make a good king.

PASSING THE TEST

Hope to build on the confidence gained from SL series: Padikkal



I wanted to show everyone that I am capable of getting big runs like I have done throughout my First Class career and now I am really happy I showed it in the Test arena as well. Hopefully, I can take the confidence forward — India batter Devdutt Padikkal, after scoring 328 runs in the two-match series against Sri Lanka.

GIANT IN THE MAKING

Pujara praises Dinusha, says he can become one of Lanka’s greats



Cheteshwar Pujara hailed Sonal Dinusha for his sensational performance against India, saying it took him back to the era of Sri Lankan giants Kumar Sangakkara and Mahela Jayawardene. “He can be one of the greats for his country. The way he batted on the last day of the second Test, it was a commendable effort”.

MEMORABLE MOMENT

Velavan defeats local hope to bag Budapest Squash Open crown



India’s Velavan Senthilkumar, seeded eighth, won the Budapest Squash Open after thrashing ninth-seeded Balazs Farkas of Hungary 11-4, 11-2, 11-3 in the final on Friday. The 28-year-old had defeated compatriot Veer Chotrani 9-11, 11-8, 11-7, 1-11, 12-10 in a last-four clash of the \$43,500 PSA Copper event.

REWARD

Hockey India announces ₹50 lakh for women’s team



Hockey India on Friday announced a cash award of ₹50 lakh for the women’s team in recognition of its fifth-place finish at the World Cup. Salima Tete’s side defeated Germany 3-1 in Amstelveen on Thursday, marking India’s best result at the tournament since the fourth-place effort at the inaugural edition in 1974.

Praggnanandhaa storms to Grand Chess Tour title

The Chennai GM bounces back in style to pip defending champion Caruana in the final by displaying his supremacy in faster time controls, becomes the first Indian to win the prestigious event

CHESS

P.K. Ajith Kumar

He was trailing. And he was up against the World No. 2. And yet, there was almost a sense of inevitability to it. R. Praggnanandhaa duly defeated Fabiano Caruana and won the Grand Chess Tour. After losing the first game, he bounced back in great style to win the multi-format final at St. Louis on Thursday. He became the first Indian to win the most prestigious tour on the chess circuit. Caruana, in fact, was the champion of the Grand Chess Tour last year, and also in 2023. He had begun on the right note in the US city, winning the opening classical game of the final

against his 21-year-old rival from Chennai, whose blunder with his rook on the 28th move proved fatal. Praggnanandhaa, however, came back strongly in the second classical game, in which he was in control before an error of judgment allowed his American opponent to draw after 95 moves. Caruana thus maintained his lead, 9-3 (a classical win carried six points). The Indian, however, showed his supremacy in the faster time controls. He won both the rapid games – worth four points each – and thus took an 11-9 lead going into the blitz section. Caruana was in a must-win situation in the last blitz game, but Praggnanandhaa drew it with perpetual checks, giving him a 15-13 match victory. He is indeed looking unstoppable on the chess-



Unstoppable: Praggnanandhaa rallied to edge out Caruana and registered one of his biggest triumphs. FLICKR/GRANDCHESSTOUR



board. This is his second major success at St. Louis this month. Just a fortnight ago, he had won the Saint Louis Rapid & Blitz in spectacular style. He won the tournament by a margin of

1.5 points, over his nearest rival Javokhir Sindarov, this year’s World championship challenger. And Praggnanandhaa was leading on all five days of the event. Before Saint Louis, he

had recorded a career-best performance at Norway Chess in Oslo, where he emerged as the champion after beating the World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen twice in his hometown. The five-

time World champion has often spoken highly of him and once even named him as the player closest to him in style. That is indeed high praise. Pravin Thipsay, In-

dia’s third Grandmaster, believes Praggnanandhaa has earned it. “He has a great sense of what is required to win, and it is not about a better position or a complex posi-

tion,” Thipsay tells *The Hindu* over the phone from Mumbai. “He has a knack of where that initiative is and goes for non-simplification like Carlsen. And he goes beyond the book and is a very active player even when the positions are equal. He has become a very strong player practically.” Praggnanandhaa’s recent successes have come after he went through one of the worst periods of his career. He was so badly out of form in the year’s most crucial event – the Candidates tournament in Cyprus, where he was placed seventh in a field of eight. If he continues to play like this, he could be one of the favourites for the next Candidates. “Yes, he will be a great force,” says Thipsay.

Robinson and Archer run riot

PAKISTAN IN ENGLAND

Agence France-Presse LONDON

Ollie Robinson took four for 11 in 13 overs as Pakistan collapsed to 110 all out in the second Test against England at Lord’s on Friday. But on a day when 13 wickets fell in total, England slumped to 13 for two in its second innings on a pitch offering significant seam movement. The home side, however, recovered to 81 for three, earning a lead of 261 when bad light forced an early close to the second day. England is seeking an unassailable 2-0 lead in the three-match series. Pakistan’s slump either side of lunch left it 180 runs behind England’s first-innings score of 290. Fast bowler Jofra Archer, who did the initial damage, took three for 26. Only opener Azan Awaais offered resistance for Pakistan with 46 while Saud Shakeel (16) was the only other batter to get to double-figures. The scores: England 290 in 66.4 overs (Cox 55, Smith 61, Mohd. Abbas 4/73, Mohd. Ali 3/86) & 81/3 in 22 overs vs. Pakistan 110 in 37.2 overs (Awaais 46, Robinson 4/11, Archer 3/26).



Robinson. GETTY IMAGES

India’s path to WTC final becomes tougher despite the series win



Tall order: India is placed fifth in the WTC points table and has seven Tests left against New Zealand and Australia in this cycle. PTI

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

K.C. Vijaya Kumar COLOMBO

Thursday’s slow winding down of the second Test, had shades of the 1980s. Back then as the game stretched into the mandatory overs of the fifth day, Sunil Gavaskar or a Javed Miandad would wheel their arm over. The fact that Shubman Gill, Yashasvi Jaiswal and Dhruv Jurel ambled towards the bowling crease, also reflected the way India’s fortunes had crashed in a drawn contest that was all about Sri Lanka’s fightback. During the course of this game at the Sinhalese Sports Club (SSC) Ground, a charity match in another venue had featured Arjuna Ranatunga and Aravinda de Silva. Just as nostalgia’s waves drenched the Sri Lankan cricketing fraternity, a hint of batting evolution was also underlined by the magnificent Sonal Dinusha. The southpaw amassed 420 runs averaging 140,

Sri Lanka-India Test series in numbers

BATTING	Inns	Runs	HS	Avg	100s/50s
Dinusha	4	420	133*	140.00	3/1
Padikkal	3	328	167	109.33	2/0
Jurel	3	173	115*	86.50	1/1
BOWLING	Inns	Wkts	BBi	SR	SWI
Suthar	4	16	6/55	40.62	1
Asitha	3	10	4/31	33.30	0
Prabath	3	9	4/109	61.33	0

and specifically his unbeaten 133 in the second innings, prevented India from sweeping the series 2-0. Just like how in the past, V.V.S. Laxman undermined Australia’s best-laid plans, Dinusha did the same with the Indians. The stalemate here and Bangladesh’s heroics at Darwin and the eventual 1-1 verdict in the series Down Under, has further affected India, placed fifth in the ICC World Test Championship (WTC) points table. The two-Test away series in New Zealand and the five games against Australia in the Indian backyard, have become must-win options for Gill’s men. If recency-bias forces a

closer scrutiny over events at the SSC, it would be prudent to recall that India’s inexplicable vulnerability at home, like the loss to South Africa, had a bearing on the team’s position in the WTC cycle. Stepping into this two-Test series without the services of the injured trio of Jasprit Bumrah, Sai Sudharsan and Washington Sundar, churn was evident in the Indian ranks. But the manner in which Player-of-the-Series Devdutt Padikkal batted in both Tests, and the glimpses of classical talent that left-arm spinner Manav Suthar offered, augurs well. Stepping in at No. 3, Padikkal, as Sri Lankan coach Gary Kirsten mentioned,

revealed good Test bat-manship. His tons at Galle and in the Sri Lankan capital had both solidity and fluidity. The southpaw never got into a shell, kept the scoreboard ticking and perhaps has done enough to stay on at No. 3 even after Sai Sudharsan returns. Suthar, meanwhile, has an old-world feel. He goads the ball to spin a yarn and leads batters to their doom. While much has been discussed about a batting order that has moved on from Rohit Sharma, Cheteshwar Pujara, Virat Kohli and Ajinkya Rahane, it is a fact that the spin-quotient will miss the guile of R. Ashwin for sometime. While Rishabh Pant and Jurel made vital contributions with the bat, the no-balls peddled by the spinners, specifically Ravindra Jadeja, and the altercation between Jaiswal and Asitha Fernando, were all a cause for worry. The road ahead is critical and coach Gautam Gambhir and Gill have to forge a squad that will prosper both at home and away.

India goes down fighting to Belgium

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad WAVRE (BELGIUM)

India could only manage an eighth-place finish in the hockey World Cup after a 3-4 penalty shootout loss to Belgium. India had fought back twice from a goal down to hold the co-host 3-3 in regulation time at the Belifus Arena here on Friday. At 2-2, veteran midfielder Manpreet Singh was struck near his eye as he put his body on the line to get on the end of Hugo Labouchere’s close-range shot. A bloodied Manpreet was helped off the pitch. But even as the Indian team could recover from the horror injury, Belgium pounced on an error to score through Nicolas de Kerpel. The goal was upheld despite India’s referral for a touch on the body in the build-up, which added to a frustratingly mixed afternoon for skipper Harmanpreet Singh. In the first quarter, he was the recipient of a five-minute suspension for an embarrassing situation when his side fielded 12 players before being hand-

ed a green card in the third. But in between them, he struck with his trademark powerful drag-pushes to twice equalise, the second one coming with just seconds left on the clock to level the scores. However, he couldn’t find a way past Vincent Vanasch in the shootout as did his teammate Sukhjeet Singh. India goalkeeper Mohith H.S. committed too early as Belgium managed to find the net four times to end its home World Cup with something to cheer about. India silenced the home side five minutes into the start when Abhishek Nain’s shot deflected in off Alexander Hendrickx for the opening goal. But Belgium continued to suffocate India with its full court press and launched a barrage of shots. While Suraj Karkera resisted in the opening quarter, Mohith couldn’t stop an unmarked Roman Duvekot from equalising before Labouchere scored from Belgium’s fifth PC. The result: India 3 (Abhishek 5, Harmanpreet 30, 59-pc) drew with Belgium 3 (Duvekot 21, Labouchere 22-pc, de Kerpel 46). Belgium won 4-3 in penalty shootout.



Bittersweet: It was a mixed day for Harmanpreet. HOCKEY INDIA



Federer. AFP

Federer to be inducted into Tennis Hall of Fame

Associated Press NEW YORK

Roger Federer loved to win, of course, and at the peak of his career, almost always did. All those victories and trophies he piled up would have made Federer an icon in tennis, but they were only part of the reason he enjoyed playing. Only after he finished competing did he realise how much that impacted his legacy in the sport. “There was a lot of talk about my personality and what I brought to the game overall when I wasn’t on court, which surprised me,” Federer said. “I thought it was about forehands, backhands, saving break points, victories and all that stuff. “But it is about what you were remembered for... how did you behave in the locker rooms or in the corridors or maybe with the media, tournament directors, ball kids,” added the 45-year-old from Switzerland. Federer will have a chance to reflect back on it on Saturday when he is enshrined in the International Tennis Hall of Fame in Newport, Rhode Island.

Weekend Sport



GETTY IMAGES

Why is Alexandra Eala, the 21-year-old from the Philippines, drawing huge crowds around the world? And how could this play out at the year's final Major in the USA, which has a history of rewarding marketable athletes and turning them into brands unto themselves?

N. Sudarshan

There are two places in the world where you would want to do well as a tennis player. The first is Wimbledon, because of its history, prestige and the sheer romance of playing in pristine white on lush green grass, the sport's original combination. Then comes the United States of America, with all its glitz, glamour and the seemingly unlimited marketing potential that can turn sportspersons into walking billboards and brands unto themselves. Being a nation of immigrants, it is a melting pot of multiple ethnicities and home to many diasporas, which means every achievement has a de facto worldwide audience.

Capturing the imagination

Over the last two months, Alexandra Eala has aced this twin-test and captured the transatlantic imagination, and of the world at large. At Wimbledon, she put together her best Grand Slam streak by reaching the fourth round, the first from the Philippines to do so. En route, she dethroned six-time Major winner Iga Swiatek in straight sets. Weeks later in Washington, she came up with another stirring run to clinch the Mubadala DC

“We have a really strong sense of community, and we uplift each other. When positive things happen to other Filipinos around the world, we share the happiness”
ALEXANDRA EALA

Open WTA 500, her first-ever Tour title. Eala beat Slam finalists Qinwen Zheng and Leylah Fernandez, No. 10 Elina Svitolina, four-time Major champion Naomi Osaka and No. 3 Jessica Pegula. The come-from-behind victory over Pegula – the 2024 US Open runner-up – came in a rain-affected final played across two days, and saw an astonishing 6-0 scoreline in the decider. The performance helped the 21-year-old break into the world's top-20 – she is No. 18 now – and sent her fame skyrocketing. So much so that sportswear behemoth Nike designed a signature black t-shirt, replete with Sampaguita flower motifs and Tagalog phrases – the Philippines' national flower and native tongue – and it sold out instantly! Ahead of the season's fourth and final Slam starting this Sunday (August 30) in the United States, 'Eala Mania' is tennis' foremost buzz phrase. “It's so refreshing and nice to see how they've embraced her, and how well she has handled the stardom that has come with her being from the Philippines,” Pegula said after the Washington final. “It's crazy how she deals with it every single week, which just shows her maturity as a player and a person. It's cool to see what she's brought to the women's game.” Sports fandom, at times, can seem irrational,

emotionally charged and borderline delusional, but the investment in Eala appears to follow a certain logic. For one, she is a top-notch tennis player, seen not just in her recent form but also from last year when she made the semifinal in Miami while ranked 140. She beat 2017 French Open champion Jelena Ostapenko, 2025 Australian Open winner Madison Keys, and Swiatek consecutively. In fact, the contests versus Keys and Swiatek were her first against top-10 players. Since then, she has accumulated seven more top-10 wins, including five in her last six outings. According to the Australian Open website, since 1990, only three other players have had more wins in their first 13 matches against top-10 opposition – Martina Navratilova, Monica Seles and Steffi Graf. The lefty angle Secondly, Eala is a lefty, a species instantly placed in a different aesthetic category. And the tennis universe appears desperate for the next left-handed Major champion, for there is none active now among men or women, with the last being Marketa Vondrousova at Wimbledon in 2023. There is her connection with 22-time Slam titlist Rafael Nadal, whose academy she trained at starting 2018 before graduating in 2023.



It's refreshing to see how well she has handled the stardom that has come with her being from the Philippines. It's cool to see what she's brought to the women's game
JESSICA PEGULA

“She is fearless and takes the ball early,” former World No. 4 Greg Rusedski – a fellow southpaw – said on his podcast. “Her mentality is so good and strong. The one area she needs to win a Major is to get that serve a bit better and more powerful. If she can get that, she's definitely in the mix because the rest of her game is there.” Thirdly, she is from Asia, an outlier in tennis success stories when compared to Europe and America. From Li Na to Kei Nishikori to Naomi Osaka, all have had fervent fan followings because Asia has been thirsty for torchbearers. It helps that the continent is expected to be the next driver of the world economy and among the biggest markets, thereby increasing a sportsperson's commercial value in the region. Also, in a developing nation like the Philippines, which isn't historically known for wide-ranging sporting excellence, an athlete's journey often intertwines with that of the nation and their goals become synonymous. It is clear in the case of Eala and tennis, for the Southeast Asian archipelago is more famous for boxing and basketball. Manny Pacquiao, one of the greatest professional boxers of all-time, is Eala's compatriot, and after the latter's triumph in Washington, he wrote on social media: “Down in the first round [set] but got back up. That is the heart of the Filipino! Congrats Alex Eala, our new champion!” Recently, in Taguig City back home, Eala was honoured with a giant mural on a basketball court that once celebrated icons such as LeBron James and Kobe Bryant.

Strong sense of community “I think we're just very proud of where we come from,” Eala said at Wimbledon. “We have a really strong sense of community, and we uplift each other. When positive things happen to other Filipinos around the world, we share the enjoyment and the happiness.”

This group identity and cohesion was well reflected in Toronto where Eala played her first match after the title at Washington. *The Athletic* reported that Tennis Canada's head of ticketing Jason Maglantay, himself a Filipino, was inundated with queries from the diaspora about where Eala would play her opening tie. She was eventually put on centre court on a Wednesday night, and tickets sold out in 30 minutes, according to Maglantay. “A sold-out Wednesday night this early in the tournament is really unheard of,” said Karl Hale, the Canadian Open tournament director. There is every chance that this pattern will repeat at the US Open. Grand Slams neither require publicity nor need to go the extra mile to sell tickets, but Alexandra Eala in a night session at the Arthur Ashe Stadium is a match made in heaven. The United States Tennis Association lives for such moments, and has a history of awarding the world's most marketable athletes with show-court appearances. The high-profile example one can think of is the return of Maria Sharapova from her doping ban in 2017 as a wild card, on Arthur Ashe under the exotic New York night sky, sporting a sparkling black dress and a glittering jacket. Eala's career graph is nowhere close to the Russian's, for Sharapova was a five-time Major winner. But fans and businesses connect with both performance and potential. Nike, it is reported, has already designed a basketball-themed bespoke outfit for Eala. A deep run in the United States may or may not materialise, but 'Eala Mania' is here to stay!

STACKING UP



ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	12,800	17
2	Alexander Zverev	29	7,790	20
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	7,160	17
4	Felix Auger-Aliassime	26	4,640	22
5	Novak Djokovic	39	3,770	16
6	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,720	26
7	Alex de Minaur	27	3,650	24
8	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,580	23
9	Ben Shelton	23	3,480	22
10	Taylor Fritz	28	3,475	22
11	Arthur Fils	22	3,140	18
12	Frances Tiafoe	28	2,680	22
13	Rafael Jodar	19	2,671	22
14	Lorenzo Musetti	24	2,605	22
15	Learner Tien	20	2,565	22

Top Indians ▶



Sumit Nagal
Rank 234 ▲ 5 spots



Manas Dhamne
Rank 372 ▼ 4 spots



F1 Drivers' standings

#	Driver	Team	Points	Wins
1	A.K. Antonelli	Mercedes	242	6
2	G. Russell	Mercedes	183	2
3	L. Hamilton	Ferrari	183	1
4	L. Norris	McLaren	159	2
5	C. Leclerc	Ferrari	155	1
6	M. Verstappen	Red Bull	112	0
7	O. Piastri	McLaren	104	0
8	I. Hadjar	Red Bull	68	0
9	L. Lawson	RB	49	0
10	P. Gasly	Alpine	44	0
11	A. Lindblad	RB	23	0
12	F. Colapinto	Alpine	19	0
13	O. Bearman	Haas	18	0
14	G. Bortoleto	Audi	10	0
15	N. Hulkenberg	Audi	6	0
16	C. Sainz	Williams	6	0
17	A. Albon	Williams	5	0
18	E. Ocon	Haas	3	0
19	F. Alonso	Aston Martin	3	0
20	V. Bottas	Cadillac	0	0
21	S. Perez	Cadillac	0	0
22	L. Stroll	Aston Martin	0	0

Top Indians ▶



A.K. Antonelli



G. Russell



Badminton Men's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	Jonatan Christie	87,631	17
2	Christo Popov	87,002	20
3	Kunlavut Vitidsarn	86,915	16
4	Chou Tien Chen	86,580	27
5	Anders Antonsen	85,405	17
6	Shi Yu Qi	84,075	12
7	Alex Lanier	78,715	16
8	Kodai Naraoka	76,530	20
9	Victor Lai	76,465	18
10	Li Shi Feng	71,683	16
11	Alwi Farhan	71,619	19
12	Lin Chun-Yi	71,274	19
13	Lakshya Sen	65,573	21
14	Loh Kean Yew	64,100	20
15	Toma Junior Popov	62,697	20

Top Indians ▶



Lakshya Sen
Rank 13



Ayush Shetty
Rank 20



Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	874	898
2	Joe Root	850	932
3	Steve Smith	840	947
4	Travis Head	811	884
5	Temba Bavuma	775	806
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rishabh Pant	711	801
8	Shubman Gill	711	807
9	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
10	Babar Azam	709	882

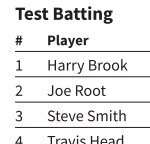
Top Indians ▶



Shubman Gill
Rank 13



Daryl Mitchell
Rank 20



Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	872	872
2	Jasprit Bumrah	862	908
3	Matt Henry	861	870
4	Pat Cummins	841	914
5	Marco Jansen	825	825
6	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
7	Scott Boland	804	820
8	Noman Ali	792	853
9	Josh Hazlewood	783	864
10	Nathan Lyon	731	812

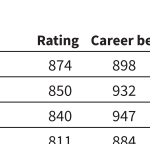
Top Indians ▶



Jasprit Bumrah
Rank 13



Noman Ali
Rank 20



ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	801	841
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	767	908
4	Rohit Sharma	758	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Joe Root	674	810
8	Shai Hope	673	782
9	Charith Asalanka	659	705
10	Harry Tector	653	730

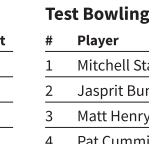
Top Indians ▶



Shubman Gill
Rank 13



Daryl Mitchell
Rank 20



ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	714	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	715	675
3	Jofra Archer	649	682
4	Keshav Maharaj	645	737
5	Mitchell Santner	644	656
6	Maheesh Theekshana	641	680
7	Adil Rashid	613	631
8	Shaheen Afridi	604	691
9	Mehidy Hasan	602	722
10	Adil Rashid	599	671

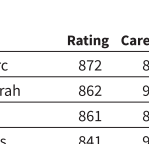
Top Indians ▶



Rashid Khan
Rank 13



Adil Rashid
Rank 20



T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	910	910
2	Sahibzada Farhan	848	848
3	Abhishek Sharma	819	931
4	Phil Salt	799	881
5	Pathum Nissanka	751	796
6	Tilak Varma	750	845
7	Jos Buttler	748	794
8	Harry Brook	734	734
9	Mitchell Marsh	706	706
10	Dewald Brevis	702	738

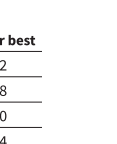
Top Indians ▶



Ishan Kishan
Rank 13



Sahibzada Farhan
Rank 20



T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	753	828
2	Abrar Ahmed	736	757
3	Adil Rashid	710	747
4	Adam Zampa	700	746
5	Nathan Ellis	675	678
6	Corbin Bosch	669	745
7	Wanindu Hasaranga	668	809
8	Mujeeb Ur Rahman	663	757
9	Varun Chakravarthy	663	818
10	Mohammad Nawaz	658	672

Top Indians ▶



Rashid Khan
Rank 13



Adil Rashid
Rank 20

